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Van hits top gear

Joshua Van **retained** his UFC flyweight title with a unanimous-decision victory over Alexandre Pantoja.

Nigamanth P

nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

Joshua Van (**above, left**) put any lingering questions over his place atop the UFC flyweight division to rest, delivering a composed five-round performance to defeat former champion Alexandre Pantoja (**above, right**) by unanimous decision at UFC 331 in Los Angeles.

Van retained his flyweight belt with scorecards of 49-46, 48-47 and 50-45 at Crypto.com Arena, completing a compelling second chapter to a rivalry that had ended abruptly in their first meeting.

The 24-year-old started aggressively, mixing his grappling with pressure and forcing Van into difficult exchanges early on.

However, the champion gradually found his rhythm, using his speed and striking accuracy to limit Pantoja's opportunities and dictate through the middle rounds.

Van finished strongly, increasing his output in the fifth and scoring a knockdown as he pulled away on the judges' scorecards.

The co-main event produced a much quicker statement. Arman Tsarukyan stopped Mauricio Ruffy with a pair of elbows at 4:56 of the opening round, extending his winning streak to six fights.

Ruffy had initially defended several takedown attempts and landed a clean right hand, but Tsarukyan adjusted in the clinch before finding the finishing sequence. The Armenian lightweight's victory strengthened his case for another championship opportunity after his previous title chance fell through.

He had been scheduled to challenge Islam Makhachev for the lightweight belt at UFC 311 in January last year, only to withdraw during fight week because of a reported back injury.

Ruffy, meanwhile, suffered his first UFC defeat since joining the promotion's lightweight ranks.

Sean Sharaf also delivered one of the night's biggest shocks, stopping highly touted Olympic wrestling gold medallist Gable Steveson with a left hand just 12 seconds into their heavyweight bout.



Did you know?

Sharaf's 12-second knockout of Steveson came with a unique financial twist.

Sharaf had revealed that he was carrying more than \$600,000 in debt while trying to establish himself as a professional fighter. After his stunning victory, he received a \$50,000 bonus. But Dana White decided to go a step further. The UFC CEO personally added another \$50,000, taking Sharaf's total bonus to \$100,000.

White said the additional money would help Sharaf tackle his debt, explaining that he wanted to help "knock a hundred grand off" what Sharaf owed.

Same rivalry, different turf

The rivalry between Colby Covington and Belal Muhammad was forged in the UFC, where both became prominent figures in the welterweight division.

At RAF 13 in Miami, however, Covington had the upper hand as their rivalry moved from MMA to the wrestling mat.

Real American Freestyle (RAF) is a professional freestyle wrestling promotion founded by former Olympic wrestler and UFC star T.J. Dillashaw and his partners.

The league has attracted several MMA fighters and wrestlers, offering crossover matchups under freestyle rules. Unlike MMA, RAF contests prohibit striking and submissions, placing the emphasis on takedowns, control and scoring.

Covington quickly established control, scoring a four-point takedown before adding to his lead. Muhammad struggled to generate offence and was eventually penalised for passivity. Covington reached 10 points in the second period to seal the technical-fall victory and remain unbeaten in RAF competition.